



▲ The full house



▲ The Mozilla camp in action



▲ Saifi Khan talks about open source firewalls



▲ Dextor in a workshop



▲ InstallFast: helping elders in the installation process



▲ Participants grab a quick bite

Day 1: Programming, storage, networking, et al.

Day 1, which was February 13, started with workshops and four parallel tech tracks. Manjusha Joshi led a workshop on the TeX/LaTeX documentation tool, followed by Rajesh Sola's hands-on tricks and tips on OpenOffice.org. Ebenezer and Samar also held a workshop in another classroom on *Tweaking Ubuntu*, wherein they showed us how to configure Ubuntu, connect to the repository, *apt-get* the required packages, create an ISO image, etc. They also demonstrated VirtualBox and how to run Ubuntu on Ubuntu.

The scheduled talks from Day 1 could be broadly classified into three streams:

- The programmers' track
- Storage and networking
- The PHP marathon

To start with, I attended a talk on open source firewalls by Saifi Khan. It mainly covered how a firewall is not just an application software running on a single computer but has to deal with the complete network infrastructure. He explained the support available in FreeBSD, NetBSD and Linux for writing firewalls, and followed that with a talk on *iptables* usage with practical demonstrations.

Next, I listened to a short but interesting talk about the Generic Netlink Socket framework by Alok Barsode. He explained this powerful IPC technique in detail and this was followed by a practical demonstration of a driver written using the Generic Netlink framework.

The next talk I attended was equally exciting. Ajay Kumar, winner of the Google Summer of Code 2008, spoke on the humanitarian FOSS project dubbed 'Sahana', explaining the technology involved and the challenges it faced.

I then attended a session on an open source library management system called 'Koha'. Krishnan Mani started with how he himself ended up getting Koha up and running for his community library. He also talked about the deployment of Koha in India

and abroad, and various techniques to migrate to Koha from existing 'spreadsheets'.

Being a kernel enthusiast myself, I next headed over towards the kernel discussion panel organised by *GeeP-Geeks of Pune*. Linux kernel gurus like Amit Shah, Amit Kale, Anand Mitra and Kedar Sovani chaired the panel and addressed questions like how different kernel programming is, how to start off with it, what the challenges are in debugging, how and where to get support and documentation from, etc.

On the same day, I also got a chance to peep into an 'Install Fest' activity for the Fedora core Linux distribution. I found students as well as elders trying out Fedora installations and coming out with a degree of confidence.

Day 2: Mozilla, Fedora and more programming

Workshops on the second day consisted of a hands-on session led by Abhishek Nagar. Aligned with the PHP marathon, as the name '*Fast track websites—from local to remote*' suggests, the workshop was based on how to build a website using Drupal. Running parallel, Vinay Pawar (a.k.a Zoid) led another hands-on session on 'Blender', making people think in a third dimension.

The scheduled talks from Day 2 could again be classified under:

- A programmer's track
- The Mozilla Camp and networking
- The PHP marathon (continued) and a Fedora activity day

Being a programmer, I chose a talk by B.C. Sekar on *Doing Linux Projects*. The talk focused on the power and benefits FOSS offers as a project development platform. He also introduced the audience to the basic licences, such as GPL and LGPL and other things a developer needs to know before contributing to an open source project. He shared his experiences in enabling his customers to achieve an improved time-to-market, using off-the-shelf FOSS tools as against the lengthy